

was born into a theatrical and musical family—one of his cousins married Mozart. He was a sickly child but precociously gifted, publishing his first composition at the age of 12 and seeing his first opera performed at 14. He was an outstanding pianist; his keyboard works demand exceptional virtuosity. Often in financial difficulties, he was exiled from Württemberg after being imprisoned for embezzlement in 1810. As a conductor he brought a fresh perfectionism to performances at opera houses in Breslau, Prague, and finally Dresden, where he directed the German Opera from 1817. His magical opera *Der Freischütz*, written at Dresden, was an international success and has remained his most famous work. It was followed by *Euryanthe*, an opera seen as paving the way for Wagner. Suffering from tuberculosis, Weber died in London, where he had traveled to conduct the premiere of his *Singspiel* (music drama) *Oberon*. He was 39 years old.

KEY WORKS: *Invitation to the Dance* (piano solo), 1819; *Der Freischütz* (opera), 1821; *Euryanthe* (opera), 1823; *Oberon* (*Singspiel*), 1826

Giacomo Meyerbeer

1791–1864, GERMAN

The most successful composer of Romantic grand opera,